aimed at ultra-Orthodox Jews usually depict only men and boys – never women and girls.[4]

In 2011, a scandal erupted when the ultra-Orthodox Brooklyn paper *Di Tzeitung* published a photo of American officials watching the raid on Osama bin-Laden's compound but digitally erased all women from the photo, including Secretary of State Hillary Clinton. The paper explained it was forced to do so by Jewish 'laws of modesty'. A similar scandal erupted when *HaMevaser* paper expunged Angela Merkel from a photo of a demonstration against the *Charlie Hebdo* massacre, lest her image arouse any lustful thoughts in the minds of devout readers. The publisher of a third ultra-Orthodox newspaper, *Hamodia*, defended this policy by explaining that 'We are backed by thousands of years of Jewish tradition.'[5]

Nowhere is the ban on seeing women stricter than in the synagogue. In Orthodox synagogues women are carefully segregated from the men, and must confine themselves to a restricted zone where they are hidden behind a curtain, so that no men will accidentally see the shape of a woman as he says his prayers or reads scriptures. Yet if all this is backed by thousands of years of Jewish tradition and immutable divine laws, how to explain the fact that when archaeologists excavated ancient synagogues in Israel from the time of the Mishnah and Talmud, they found no sign of gender segregation, and instead uncovered beautiful floor mosaics and wall paintings depicting women, some of them rather scantily dressed? The rabbis who wrote the Mishnah and Talmud regularly prayed and studied in these synagogues, but present-day Orthodox Jews would consider them blasphemous desecrations of ancient traditions.[6]

Similar distortions of ancient traditions characterise all religions. The Islamic State has boasted that it has reverted to the pure and original version of Islam, but in truth, their take on Islam is brand new. Yes, they quote many venerable texts, but they exercise a lot of discretion in choosing which texts to quote and which to ignore, and in how to interpret them. Indeed, their do-it-yourself attitude to interpreting the holy texts is itself very modern. Traditionally, interpretation was the monopoly of the learned *ulama* – scholars who studied Muslim law and theology in reputable institutions such as Cairo's Al-Azhar. Few of the Islamic State's leaders have had such credentials, and most respected *ulama* have dismissed Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi and his ilk as ignorant criminals.[7]

That does not mean that the Islamic State has been 'un-Islamic' or 'anti-Islamic', as some people argue. It is particularly ironic when Christian leaders such as Barack Obama have the temerity to tell self-professing Muslims such as Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi what it means to be Muslim.[8] The heated argument about the true essence of Islam is simply pointless. Islam has no fixed DNA. Islam is whatever Muslims make of it.[9]